EXHIBITION

United by Art

Moments in Collapse, SAHMAT's group exhibition at **Jawahar Bhawan** in Delhi brings together artworks with politically charged themes

Artist Pushpamala N.'s 30-second video installation 'Urgent Saaru' is one of the most intriguing parts of *Moments in Collapse*, a group exhibition by SAHMAT (Safdar Hashmi Memorial Trust) at Delhi's Jawahar Bhawan, which is on till June 20. This is a recording of a live performance—the video sees Pushpamala dressed as 'Bharat Mata', recreating a rasam recipe by her late friend and neighbour, Gauri Lankesh.

"The video by Pushpamala is a recording of a live performance from a few years ago," says artist Gigi Scaria who has curated *Moments in Collapse* alongside a five-member team (Ram Rahman, Aban Raza, Vijendra S. Vij, Shatam Ray and Priyanshi S.). "When she was alive, Gauri Lankesh and Pushpamala used to have rasam together at the latter's house. This was the artist's way of honouring her dead friend's memory and also to remind people of the brutal, tragic circumstances of her death."

Moments in Collapse brings together the works of 45 artists, and most of the artworks are either responding or referring to important, politically charged themes from both Indian and world history. 'Dystopia's Spillage', a diptych by Anita Dube, is a commentary on the politics of meat consumption. Archana Hande's installation 'Ballistic Vests (Chaddi, Bra, Rumal, Shirt & Pant)' consists of wearable objects made out of security badges, cloth and safety pins. Orijit Sen's 'Liberty Is Not Your Green Statue' re-imagines the young Palestinian journalist Bisan Owda—one of the principal on-ground sources of information from the Gaza Strip—as Libertas, the Roman goddess immortalised in the Statue of Liberty.

According to Scaria, "SAHMAT has always been a group of like-minded artists who wanted to develop politically conscious works and, with this particular exhibition, I felt like there was an opportunity to bring in some younger artists as well—people who should be better known in artistic circles, whose works deserve close readings."

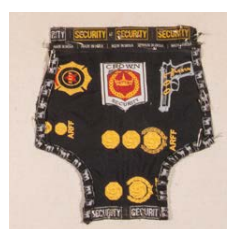
In one of the bolder, more experimental touches on display, Shilpa Gupta's untitled series of pencil-on-paper sketches sees individual protesters being hauled away by their arms and legs by a rampant police force. The catch is that all of the protesters have been drawn using silhouettes and negative spaces only—none of them have defined features of any kind whatsoever, heightening the 'anonymity' that Gupta wants to imbue these figures with. The overall effect is reminiscent of the iconic Gallos statue in Tintagel, UK (better known as the King Arthur statue), that also uses negative space in a very similar way.

Whether you're an admirer of traditional forms/methods or a follower of contemporary art, *Moments in Collapse* has much to offer to you. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha







MAKING A STATEMENT (Clockwise from top) Anita Dube's diptych 'Dystopia's Spillage', Pushpamala N.'s 'Motherland', Orijit Sen's 'Liberty Is Not Your Green Statue', Archana Hande's 'Ballistic Vests'

CURATED BY GIGI SCARIA, THE EXHIBITION SHOWCASES WORKS OF 45 ARTISTS